The highest-ranking noblemen of the court contributed to increasing the visible glory of the court and empire. At this time, it was Akbar's foster brother, Zain Khan Koka, who begged of Akbar for a visit to his house. As we have seen, a personal visit by the Padshah was the greatest honour that a nobleman could hope for and when Akbar agreed to visit him, Zain Khan Koka arranged for celebrations that matched in extravagance and exquisite detail the magnitude of this honour. The homes of these elite noblemen were themselves lavish, with gardens and water tanks and many apartments. Often built of rubble and mud, they were covered with a white plaster that was the envy of visiting Europeans. Dutch merchant Francisco Pelsaert has described this plaster, of unslaked lime mixed with milk, gum and sugar, applied on the walls with a trowel and polished until the walls shone like mirrors. As the emperor and his retinue arrived, baskets filled with jewels were presented as peshkash, in addition to elephants. An entire terrace was covered with rare and expensive toosh shawls. Instead of water sprinklers, Zain Khan Koka had the grounds of the courtyard sprayed with a syrup of milk, sugar, and Yazd roses to settle the dust. Three tanks were dug in front of the terrace—one filled with rose water from Yazd, one with water coloured yellow with saffron, the third with argaja, a perfume. A thousand courtesans were thrown into the tanks so that their fine garments were all stained different colours.

By the end of the sixteenth century, these mansabdars of the Mughal Empire were extremely wealthy men. According to one estimate, all the officers together, some 1,671 persons, controlled 82 per cent of the net revenue resources of the empire, with the top 25 mansabdars alone accounting for 30 per cent.[*] As the noblemen of the Mughal court became wealthier, they spent increasingly large amounts on charities, endowments, and patronage, especially in their own parganas. Shaikh Farid Bukhari had made a list of all the Sayyids of Gujarat and gave them money, met the wedding expenses of their sons and daughters, provided subsistence to all the residents of khanqahs and darweshes,[†] and looked after the widows of all the men who died in his service. Mir Abul Qasim Arghun devised a rather novel method for charity in Sind. He would have entire panels of cloth hung from the branches of trees in the forest and would have herds of horses, cows, and buffaloes released into them so that poorer folk could help themselves to what they needed. Ram Das Kachhwaha donated money